

Wolfe County, Kentucky Case Study

Demographics

Population: 6,484

Land area: 222.2 square miles (population density $\approx$ 29.2 people per square mile)

Median age: $\sim$ 41.5 years

Gender: $\sim$ 50.7% female, 49.3% male

Race/Ethnicity: 96.1% White (non-Hispanic), 1.6% Hispanic, 1.5% two or more races

Social/Economic

Median household income: \$29,052

Per capita income: \$15,253

Poverty rate: 38.1% of population

Child poverty (under 18): 39.5%

Median property value: \$66,400

Food Insecurity Rate: 24.0 %

Child Food Insecurity Rate: 25%

Good info about healthcare:

https://www.chfs.ky.gov/agencies/os/codata/Wolfe_LegislativeReport_2024.pdf

Political

County seat: Campton

Political leaning: Historically Democratic but has shifted Republican in recent elections

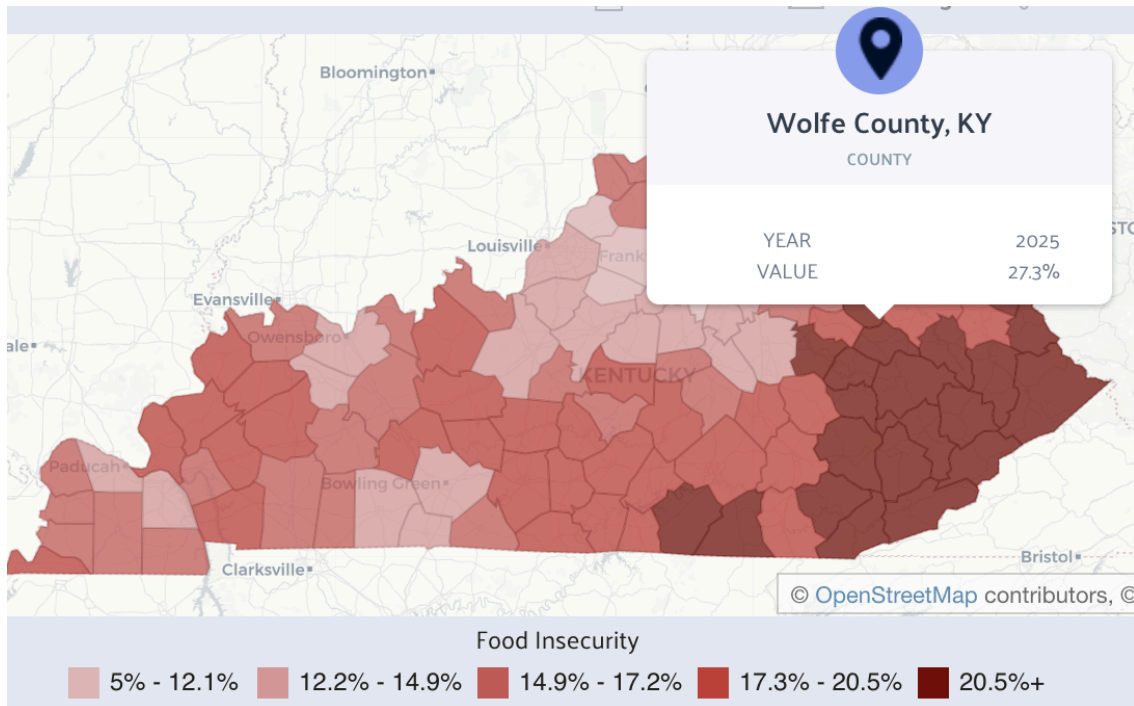
Local government programs: Limited county-level initiatives for food security and public health; residents often rely on regional and state aid such as SNAP and the Kentucky Department of Community Based Services

Community organizations addressing food insecurity: God's Pantry Food Bank (partner sites in Eastern Kentucky), Appalachian Outreach Inc., and Red River Community Center

Food Organizations

1. Hazel Green Food Project: Distributes fresh produce and food boxes across Eastern Kentucky, including Wolfe County residents.
2. God's Pantry Food Bank: Regional network supplying food pantries and mobile markets serving rural Central and Eastern Kentucky.
3. Feeding Kentucky: Statewide coalition coordinating hunger relief and distributing nutritious foods through partner food banks.

4. Farms to Food Banks Program: Purchases surplus produce from Kentucky farmers to supply pantries with fresh fruits and vegetables.
5. Appalachian Outreach, Inc.: Provides emergency food, clothing, and disaster relief assistance to families in Wolfe and nearby counties.
6. Red River Community Center: Local site offering community meals, food pantry distributions, and youth nutrition activities.
7. Kentucky Department for Community Based Services (SNAP): Administers Supplemental



Nutrition Assistance Program benefits for eligible Wolfe County households.

Political

- Majority voted for Trump in last 3 elections (74.1%, 70.4%, 68.5%)
- Has voted Republican in last 5+ Presidential elections
- Has voted for Republican Senators/House Members in last 10 years
 - ~70% of county is Republican

County seat: Campton

Wolfe County has the highest food insecurity rate in Kentucky at **27.3%**, 2025

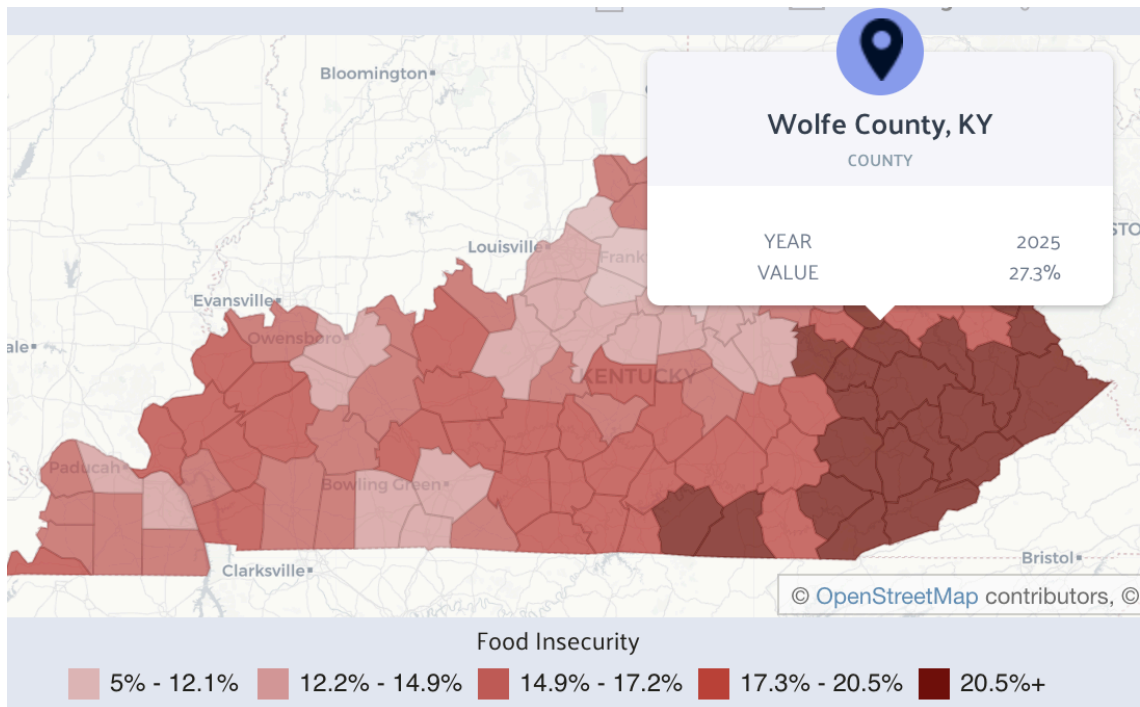
Policies:

1. [HB 367](#) → Failed Bill which would've restricted SNAP access
 - a. Would have eliminated "Broad Based Categorical Eligibility" (BBCE) and reduced the income/asset thresholds needed for food assistance
 - b. Would have made statewide the mandatory employment & training requirements for SNAP recipients aged 16–59, disqualifying many
 - c. "Would've Take Away Food Assistance from 65,000"
2. [May 2025 House Budget Plan](#) (Big Beautiful Bill) → Passed
 - a. Included huge cuts to federal food assistance, the largest reduction ever proposed in the history of SNAP, also forced states to cover at least 5% of benefits
 - b. Reduced or eliminate food assistance for many of the 575,800 Kentuckians
 - c. Work reporting rules expanded to adults 55–64 from 18-54 and families with children over age 7 (unless married with one spouse meeting work rules)
 - d. Caused 135,000 additional Kentuckians (23% of current SNAP recipients) would be at risk of losing benefits
 - e. Food banks cannot fill the gap SNAP provides 9 meals for every 1 from food pantries

Socioeconomic

- [Stats](#)
 - 2023 Population: 6,484
 - 2023 Poverty Rate: 38.1%
 - More than double the rate in Kentucky: 16.1%
 - More than double the rate in United States: 12.4%
 - Min Wage: \$7.25 per hour
 - 2023 Median Household Income: \$29,052
 - Unemployment Rate: [7%](#) (14% in Jan 2025)
 - [Number](#) of Food and Beverage Stores: 4
 - Number of Grocery Stores: n/a
 - Number of Supermarkets and other Grocery Stores (except convenience stores): n/a
 - Number of Convenience Stores: n/a
 - Number of Gasoline Stations with Convenience Store: 5
- [Largest Industries](#)
 1. Production Manufacturing (14.5%)
 2. Food Preparation & Serving Related (13.7%)
 3. Sales (12.3%)
 - a. From 2022 to 2023, employment in Wolfe County, KY declined at a rate of –1.64%, from 1.53k employees to 1.5k employees
- [Education](#)
 - Number of 2020-2021 High School: Graduates Entering College 35
 - Overall College-Going Rate: 34.7%
 - College-Going Rate - Males: 20.4%
 - College-Going Rate - Females: 48.1%
 - ["Wolfe County ranks first in the nation on Education Recovery Scorecard"](#)
- Cities in Wolfe County

1. Campton: 300
 2. Hazel Green: 7...
- Takeaways
 - High poverty, low income, loss of industry, and overall rural area/lack of grocery stores
 - 2022 [Wolfe County FAMILY/INDIVIDUAL Data](#)
 - Total Food Insecurity Rate
 - Overall Food Insecurity Rate: 24.0% (Feeding America: 28%)
 - Number of Food Insecure Persons Overall: 1,600
 - Child Food Insecurity Rate: 25.5%
 - Number of Food Insecure Children: 390
 - Food Assistance (July 2022)
 - Number of Persons Receiving SNAP: 1,952
 - Number of Households Receiving SNAP: 953
 - Food Access (2021)
 - Number of Food and Beverage Stores: 4
 - Number of Grocery Stores: n/a
 - Number of Supermarkets and other Grocery Stores (except convenience stores): n/a
 - Number of Convenience Stores: n/a
 - Number of Gasoline Stations with Convenience Store: 5
 - School Lunch (2022-2023 academic year)
 - Number of Students who are Economically Disadvantaged based upon being Program or Income Eligible for Free or Reduced-priced Meals: 906
 - Students on free or reduced price lunch: 53.0%
 - Health (Food-Related)
 - Percent of Adults Ages 20+ Diagnosed with Diabetes: 15.4%
 - Percent of Adults Ages 18+ that Report a Body Mass Index (BMI) Greater than or Equal to 30 (Obese): 44.3%
 - 2022 [Wolfe County YOUTH Development Data](#)
 - Total Food Insecurity 2021
 - Overall Food Insecurity Rate: 24.0%
 - Number of Food Insecure Persons: 1,600
 - Child Food Insecurity Rate: 25.5%
 - Number of Food Insecure Children: 390
 - YOUTH Food Assistance (2022)
 - Number of children receiving aid from Supplemental Nutrition Assistance Program (SNAP): 702 (~45% of child population)
 - Number of infants and children receiving Women, Infants, and Children assistance (WIC): 214 (~27% of Infant population)
 - [Facts](#)



- In Central and Eastern Kentucky, the meal gap has reached a historic high of 53 million meals annually
- Wolfe County Annual Food budget shortfall: \$1,118,000
- The [cost](#) of a modestly priced meal is \$3.19 in Kentucky, 11% higher than what the maximum SNAP benefit provides

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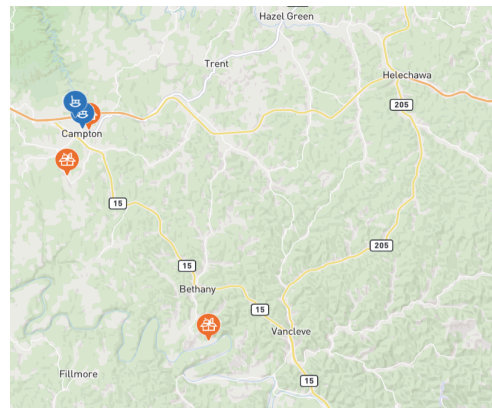
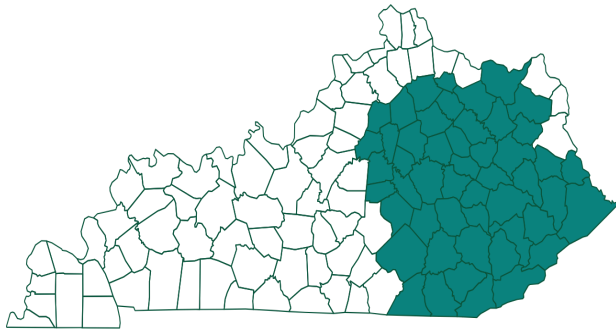


Wolfe County Local Food Pantries

Wolfe County

1. God's Pantry Food Bank

- Founded in 1955 in Lexington, Kentucky, evolved into large-scale nonprofit food bank
- “Reducing hunger by working together to feed Kentucky communities”
- Supports Wolfe county with distribution centers at local food pantries, soup kitchens, homeless shelters, schools, youth programs, meal programs, etc
- Runs the “BackPack Programs” for kids
- Member of Feeding America and Feeding Kentucky



- 51,042,266 pounds of food distributed, 42,535,222 meals distributed in FY2025
- \$1 donation = 6 meals
- Supports 19 of the most food-insecure counties in the nation



Serviced Counties in Teal (50 Counties)
Pantries/Programs in Wolfe County

Food

- Listed Food Pantries in GPFB Map
 1. KY River Area Development District
 2. Campton Community Food Pantry
 3. Wolfe County Commodity Supplemental Food Program
 4. Bethany Christian Mission Center
 5. Abiding Hope Food Pantry

2. Hazel Green Food Project

- a. Founded during COVID, smaller than above two but has expanded with help from God's Pantry, the Christian Appalachian Project, and local donors
 - b. Distributes groceries, hygiene items, mattresses, furniture, toys, and seasonal meals
- Hazel Green, 7 minutes from central WC
 - Also serves 16 more counties in SW Kentucky
 - Currently supports Wolfe County but is much smaller than GPFB

Minor Food Programs (Do not serve Wolfe County)

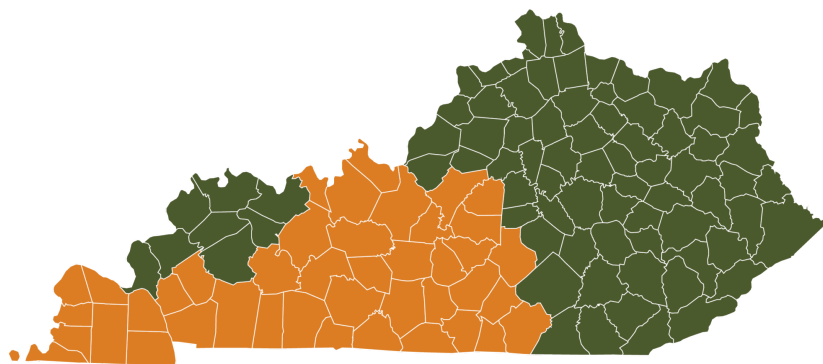
1. Feeding America, Kentucky's Heartland

- a. Founded in 1982, currently serves 42 counties across central, south-central, and southwestern Kentucky → Headquarters in Elizabethtown, Kentucky
- b. Smaller branch of Feeding America
- c. Quite far from Wolfe County and does not provide resources

Serviced Counties in Orange (42 Counties)

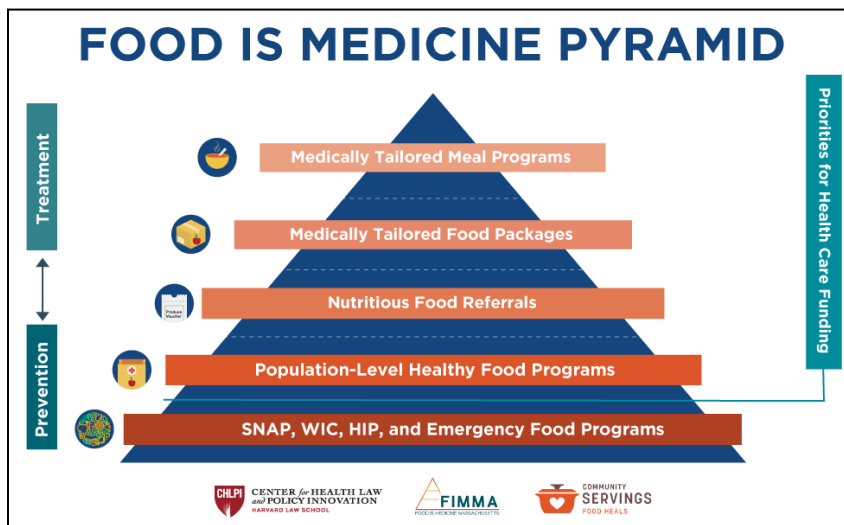
Kentucky Food Action Network

- Founded in 2019, mission: “Creating accessible and resilient food systems that prioritize the health of Kentuckians”
- Goals:
 1. “Educate and advocate state and federal officials.
 2. Provide trainings, support and collaborate with partners across our food system.
 3. Host working groups on food assistance, agriculture and the food system.
 4. Help people develop and share their story for food, farm and hunger advocacy.”
- [3 Main Policy Priorities in 2024](#)



1. Help feed more Kentuckians by improving Kentucky’s safety net
2. Feed more hungry children and support education by providing more free school meals

3. Support local agriculture and food systems and feed more hungry Kentuckians by establishing the Healthy Farm and Food Innovation Fund (HFFIF)
- Farm Bill Support
 - KY Farm Bill shapes the entire food system and is crucial to Kentucky's 76,000 farmers and 550,000 food-insecure residents
 - KFAN specifically wants the bill to:
 - Ensure broad access to SNAP and emergency food assistance
 - Strengthen local and regional food supply chains so farmers can market products and Kentuckians can access healthy, affordable food
 - Expand affordable land and resource access for all farmers, especially historically underserved groups
 - "Food as Medicine"
 - Food as Medicine Programs = Programs that provide access to nutritious foods for people that may not have access to or as part of a medical intervention
 - Wants to:
 - Use Medicaid 1115 waiver to use federal medicaid funds to pay for costs of medically-tailored meals
 - Use Medicaid Flexible Services to help cover cost of Community Supported Agriculture
 - Use Medicaid to certify children for free school meals



Political and Socioeconomic Takeaways

- High poverty, limited employment opportunities outside of a few sectors, and dependence on social assistance programs
- Strong republican support, traditional Appalachian values and a need for external funding and support → friction for reliance on state/federal programs

- Lower-than-average educational attainment levels present a long-term barrier to attracting high-skill jobs and improving earning potential for residents.

Food Insecurity and Deserts Takeaways

- Reliable access to affordable, nutritious food is a significant challenge, creating extremely high food insecurity rates which causes a cycle
- Wolfe County qualifies as a "food desert" because of the extremely limited access to large/branded or local grocery stores, requiring long travel distances for many residents to purchase healthy food
- Similarly, the lack of access to nutritious food directly contributes to higher rates of diet-related illnesses, such as diabetes and heart disease
- Reliance on smaller, local convenience stores, which generally offer limited healthy options at higher prices

Efforts and Solutions Takeaways

- Numerous local nonprofits/food banks are food pantries, emergency aid, and limited educational programs
 - However, God's Pantry Food Bank serves as the most-equipped and local food organization → Other nonprofits are either too far/not large enough
- Nonprofits/food pantries have also created links to politics for advocacy purposes and have outlined needs/priorities for upcoming policy → Kentucky Food Action Network
- The Kentucky Food Action Network has also outlined ways that food acts as medicine, but again the lack of resources/supermarkets with access to nutritious food limits these hopes